TALK ONE

# 1 The Lord

*"Prepare ye the way of the Lord, make straight in the desert a highway for our God."*

ISAIAH 40:3

If you open the Old Testament in the King James Version, you will notice that sometimes LORD is printed in all capital letters, and sometimes it isn't. That is on purpose. Where the Hebrew text uses the sacred name of God, the translators printed LORD in capitals. Where it uses an ordinary word like master, they printed Lord the usual way. The capital letters tell us whose name we are reading.

So when we call Jesus Lord, what are we saying about Him, and about ourselves? Isaiah wrote, "The voice of him that crieth in the wilderness, Prepare ye the way of the LORD," and all four Gospel writers quote those words about John the Baptist. Preparing the way was a servant's work. Before a master came home, someone went ahead to get everything ready for him. Malachi describes it that way: "Behold, I will send my messenger, and he shall prepare the way before me: and the Lord, whom ye seek, shall suddenly come to his temple." Jesus said John was that messenger. John's whole work was getting things ready for his Lord.

The word itself could carry several meanings, from ordinary courtesy to worship. In the Greek of the New Testament, it is *kurios*. When the Samaritan woman first spoke to Jesus at the well, she called Him "Sir," and it translates to this Greek word. It could also mean the master of a household. But Jewish readers used "Lord" in place of God's sacred name as well. The Gospel writers used *kurios* when quoting that name in Greek. The word alone does not tell us whether someone is being polite, recognizing a master, or speaking of God. We have to listen to what the person is saying about Him.

Our English word lord helps us picture the relationship between a master and his household. It comes from an Old English word meaning "loaf-keeper"—the person who kept the bread and gave it out. The household depended on him for food, and its members answered to him for their work. A lord had responsibility for the people in his care, and they had responsibilities to him. We do not usually hear that household meaning when we use the word today.

Calling a ruler lord could also be a declaration of loyalty. Rome ruled Judea when John preached, and people in the eastern part of the empire used the title for the emperor. Coins of Tiberius called him the son of the divine Augustus. For the Jews, these claims gave a man honor that belonged to God. The historian Josephus describes a movement whose followers said God was their only Ruler and Lord. He also tells of captured rebels, children among them, who refused, even under torture, to call Caesar their lord. Lord is the name of an office, and the question in any passage is who holds that authority. Jesus was born into a world full of lords: Caesar, Herod, and the leaders of the temple. The people were not ready to receive another.

The Jews living under Rome mostly paid its taxes and obeyed its laws, while worshipping God as their ruler. What happened when these taxes seemed to conflict with their loyalty to God? Some Pharisees and supporters of Herod brought that question to Jesus, hoping to trap Him. They asked whether it was lawful to pay tribute to Caesar. If He said yes, people could accuse Him of siding with a pagan ruler. If He said no, His enemies could report Him to Rome. Jesus asked for a coin and asked whose image and name were on it. They answered, "Caesar's." He told them, "Render therefore unto Caesar the things which are Caesar's; and unto God the things that are God's."

Jesus's answer leaves us to consider what belongs to God. The coin carried Caesar's image, but the people holding it carried another image. Genesis teaches that we were made in God's image. One way to understand Jesus's answer is that Caesar could claim his coin, while God could claim us. Paying a tax did not give Caesar everything. There was a claim on their lives that belonged to God.

That claim asks for faithfulness, something Brother Timpson describes with the word *fealty*. In the Middle Ages, a man becoming a lord's vassal would

kneel, place his hands between his lord's hands, and promise to be faithful. He owed his lord service, and his lord owed him protection. The promise was meant to govern what he did after he stood up and went home. Calling someone his lord committed him to a way of living.

A promise of faithfulness is easy to make when we agree with what we are asked to do. Sometimes I want to follow Him and still be in charge of the directions. Jesus asked His listeners, "And why call ye me, Lord, Lord, and do not the things which I say?" Then He described a person who hears His words and does them as a man who digs deep and builds his house on a rock. The house stands because the man has done the work of building on that foundation. In the same way, calling Jesus Lord asks us to build our lives around what He teaches.

John's work required him to prepare his followers to follow someone else. Crowds came to hear him, and some wondered whether he was the Christ. But John saw Jesus as his Lord, and his responsibility was to get people ready to receive Him. He described the difference between himself and the Savior by reaching for one of a servant's lowest tasks: "the latchet of whose shoes I am not worthy to stoop down and unloose." A later Jewish teaching says a student should do everything for his teacher that a servant does for his master, except untie his sandals. John said he was not worthy even to do that for Jesus. He wanted those listening to recognize the Lord he served.

When I call Jesus Lord, I want it to mean what it meant to John. He is the One I depend on and the One I answer to.

*[The speaker continues with his own testimony.]*

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*The script ends here. The speaker's own testimony follows.*